

Sales Training — Session 29

Buyers Are Liars.

Read the Real Picture. Give Them a Soft Way Out.

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WHAT THIS SESSION IS How to handle the most common stumbling block on the phone — the buyer who claims they're happy with their current SEO, even when the data on screen says otherwise. Industry benchmarks, the soft way in, the soft way out, and why "we need to catch up" gets meetings booked when nothing else will.

1. Bring a real question to training

Before we get to the content, a coaching note. Training only works when the team brings a specific, concrete question — not a topic. "How do we tackle different tiers of traffic" isn't a question. It's a category. "What do I say when a buyer with 50 traffic insists they're getting great results from their SEO" is a question. It has a specific situation, a specific objection, and demands a specific answer.

The reps who get the most out of these sessions are the ones who arrive having written down two or three real scenarios from the past week — verbatim what the buyer said, what stumped the rep, and what was missing. If you arrive without that prep, the session drifts. If you arrive with it, you walk out with three new lines that actually work.

"Give me a specific problem. Like, you know — a question that doesn't move. We can't just go on a witch hunt."

2. Industry benchmarks — and why 90% of buyers are below them

Reps need to carry industry benchmarks in their head. For trades, the working number is 500 to 1,500 organic visits per month. Anything below 500 is below industry standard. Anything below 100 is effectively invisible. Once a rep knows this number, every campaign they look at gets instantly classified — and the conversation writes itself.

The reality on the phones: roughly 90% of the businesses our reps are calling sit below industry average. That's not bad luck. That's the market. The buyers who already have great campaigns aren't on our prospect list — they're already someone's client. The list our reps work is, by definition, weighted toward underperformance.

That should change how reps frame every call. The default assumption isn't "this campaign is probably fine." The default assumption is "this campaign is probably below industry standard, and the buyer probably doesn't know it." The rep's job is to bring the data and let it speak.

Monthly traffic

What it means for trades

How to handle it on the call

Under 100	Below industry standard. Site is essentially invisible. The 'SEO' they're paying for isn't working.	Easy diagnostic. "Industry standard for trades is 500–1,500/month. You're at 50. Worth 10 minutes to see why?"
100 – 500	Below industry standard but not invisible. Usually a light or stalled campaign.	Check branded vs non-branded — most of it will be brand-name searches, which means SEO isn't earning the traffic.
500 – 1,500	Industry standard for a trade. Campaign is broadly working.	Pitch optimisation, not replacement. Look for declines, ranking slips, or page-two near-misses.
1,500+	Above standard. Either great SEO, strong brand, or paid ads.	Position as second opinion. "You're doing better than most. Happy to give a free read."

3. Branded vs non-branded — the diagnostic that exposes weak SEO

A buyer with 50 visits/month who insists their SEO is working can be diagnosed in 30 seconds. Pull up the breakdown of branded vs non-branded traffic. If nearly all of those 50 visits are people typing in the business name (branded), then SEO is contributing roughly zero — those visitors were going to find the business anyway. The buyer is paying \$700/month for traffic they would have got for free.

Non-branded traffic is the test. If they're ranking for "Sydney plumber" or "Adelaide builder" and pulling visits from those terms, the SEO is doing its job. If 49 of the 50 visits are people searching the business name, the SEO is decorative. The rep narrates that finding calmly: "Your traffic is 50. Of that 50, 49 are typing in your business name — that's brand-driven, not SEO-driven. Worth 10 minutes to look at why?"

"You've got 50 traffic, and 49 of them are typing your brand name straight in. You're currently paying for SEO, but the SEO isn't earning you that traffic — your reputation is."

4. The incognito test — let the buyer prove it to themselves

If the buyer insists they rank well, don't argue. Invite them to test it. "Just open an incognito window — type in your main keyword — tell me where you appear on the first page. My software says you're not there, but it might be wrong." Three things happen at once. The buyer participates, which makes them invested. The buyer discovers the truth themselves, which removes the rep's burden of breaking it to them. And the rep sounds reasonable rather than confrontational.

The phrase "my software might be wrong" is critical. It hands the buyer an out — they're not being told they're wrong, the rep is acknowledging their own data could be imperfect. The buyer agrees to look. The result is what it is. The rep doesn't gloat — they just transition:

"Okay, that's what we usually see. Let me book in 15 minutes with one of our specialists to show you what the campaign is actually doing."

5. Buyers are liars — what this actually means

This is the central frame of the session. "Buyers are liars" is not a cynical claim about people's moral character. It's a description of what defensive humans do when an unknown stranger calls them up trying to sell something. They are trying to get the caller off the phone. Lying — by omission, exaggeration, or fabrication — is the path of least resistance.

When a buyer says "I'm getting tons of work, I'm flat-out busy, my SEO is great" — they don't necessarily mean any of that. They mean "please leave me alone." Their goal in the conversation is not truth. Their goal is escape. The rep who takes those statements at face value is, in effect, working from corrupted data.

"Who's going to buy a car they want and say to the salesperson, 'Wow, that's exactly what I'm looking for'? You're not lying because you're evil. You're lying because you don't want to be in a vulnerable spot. Buyers do the same thing."

Three working rules follow from this. First, treat enthusiastic dismissals ("I'm great, I'm busy, I love my provider") with extra suspicion — they're usually the strongest defensive lies. Second, treat irritated specifics ("I'm paying \$700, not \$100, and my SEO is fine") as more likely true — the emotional reaction is the data point. Third, never call a buyer a liar out loud — that ends the call. Use the soft tools below instead.

6. The price jab — calibrated provocation as a lie detector

From Session 27, the rep deliberately under-quotes what they think the buyer is spending — "this looks like a light campaign, you must be paying around \$100–\$200/month, am I right?" In Session 29, Corie reframed this move as a lie detector rather than just a booking move.

Watch the response. A flat, easy "yeah, about that" is itself a lie — nobody with 50 traffic is happily paying \$100 for it. The reps are now hearing one lie stacked on another. End the call gracefully. A visceral correction — "no, I'm paying \$700!" — is the truth surfacing. The buyer is now emotionally engaged and the rep is on. Book the meeting.

"I'm looking for an emotional, visceral response — something that looks like vomit. 'No, I'm paying \$700!' — that's a sale right there."

Word it gently. Not "\$100" (insultingly low). Use a small range: "\$100 to \$200, would that be about right?" That range gives the buyer dignity. If they're really at \$700, they'll still correct you — and the correction is the meeting. If they're at \$100 and they say yes, the diagnosis is confirmed and the rep moves to the next step.

7. The soft way in — and the soft way out

Two related moves. The soft way in is how the rep raises the uncomfortable data without cornering the buyer. The soft way out is how the rep lets the buyer abandon their initial lie without losing face. Both are required. Buyers who feel cornered hang up. Buyers who are given a graceful exit from their own defensive lies become customers.

The soft way in:

- "Look, I'm just a bit confused. My software is showing 50 visits — that doesn't make a lot of sense if you're doing SEO. Can you help me understand?"
- "This looks like a really light campaign. Would I be right saying you're at \$100–\$200/month? I'm not trying to put words in your mouth — just trying to make sense of what I'm seeing."
- "Maybe my software's wrong — would you mind opening an incognito window and just checking where you rank?"

The soft way out:

- "Would you consider getting a second opinion on this? No pressure — even if you don't go with us, the report would give you something to take to your current provider."
- "Let me just send you a screenshot of what I'm seeing. You can look at it on your own time and come back to me if you want to."
- "Whether you go with us or someone else, this account isn't going anywhere right now. Worth 10 minutes to look at it together?"

Notice the structure: both moves preserve the buyer's dignity. The rep doesn't have to declare them a liar. The buyer doesn't have to admit they were lying. The data does the work. The rep just facilitates.

8. "We need to catch up" — the line that's hard to refuse

A specific verbal move that books meetings. When the rep wants to close on time, the phrase to reach for is "we need to catch up." Not "can we book a meeting," not "would you like a call," but "we need to catch up."

It works because it borrows the social grammar of running into someone you know on the street. "We need to catch up" is what people say to old friends — it's friendly, low-pressure, and almost impossible to refuse without seeming rude. The rep is using a culturally familiar phrase that bypasses the buyer's normal defensive scripts.

"We need to catch up." Have you ever had someone say that to you and replied no? It's very hard. It's embarrassing. It's a fake-friendly situation — but the energy carries it."

Two ingredients: energy and brevity. Say it warmly and confidently — "Hey, we need to catch up." Pair it immediately with a tiny time commitment — "I've got a really interesting

report for you. Just 5 to 10 minutes. I think you're going to find this useful." Energy + low time commitment = booking.

9. Time is the currency — the 50¢ painting principle

A mental model for how the buyer is actually weighing the rep's ask. When the rep asks for "half an hour" — to a stranger on a cold call — the buyer hears "give me \$5,000." When the rep asks for "5 minutes," the buyer hears "give me 50¢." Time, especially for business owners with families, is the single most expensive asset they spend, and they will not part with chunks of it for an unknown sales pitch.

Hence the discipline: every meeting ask should be quoted at 5 to 10 minutes. "I just need 5 to 10 minutes to show you the report." Not because the meeting will only take 5 minutes (it often won't) — but because the buyer needs to feel that the commitment is small enough to be safe. Once they're in the meeting and engaged, they'll happily spend an hour. The trick is getting them in.

"Treat half an hour as \$5,000. Treat 5 minutes as 50¢. When you ask, ask in the right currency. People will pay 50¢ for a painting they're curious about. They won't pay \$5,000 for one they've never seen."

The companion move: make the perceived value of the meeting much higher than the time cost. "I think you're going to love this" — said with real conviction — turns a 50¢ ask into a \$5,000-value offer. That's the painting principle. The product (the meeting, the report) needs to feel like it's worth far more than what the rep is asking for.

10. Stick to the process — don't pre-judge the buyer

A second related discipline. Reps will form opinions about buyers in the first 30 seconds — "this guy sounds broke," "this one's a tyre-kicker," "this one's a real buyer." That's natural and not always wrong. The danger is letting those opinions distort the rep's process. If the rep decides the buyer is a time-waster, the rep will treat them as a time-waster, and the buyer will leave.

The discipline is simple: hold the hypothesis internally, but run the standard process anyway. The buyer who sounds broke might be cash-rich and just casual on the phone. The buyer who pushed back hard on price might be the real buyer (people negotiate when they intend to spend, not when they don't). "Sales is backwards," as Corie put it — the people who want to buy often act like they don't, and the people complimenting you are often the ones leaving.

"Stick to your process. Only break the process for what the client actually wants — not because of what your eyes are telling you. Most rich people look broke. Most broke people look rich."

11. Action items for the team

1. Memorise the industry traffic benchmark for trades: 500–1,500 organic visits/month. Anything below 500 is your booking opportunity.
2. Before any prospect call: pull SEM Rush, check total traffic, AND check the branded vs non-branded breakdown. The branded share is the lie detector.
3. Practise the incognito test verbatim: "Just open an incognito window and check where you rank for [keyword]. My software might be wrong." Memorise the script.
4. Use the calibrated price range — "\$100 to \$200, would that be about right?" — never the bare "\$100." It's the difference between probing and insulting.
5. When the buyer says "I'm getting tons of work," don't argue. Say: "Great — that's word of mouth, your reputation. Imagine adding SEO traffic on top of that." Soft way out.
6. Replace "can we book a meeting" with "we need to catch up." Practise the warm tone — it's the energy that carries it, not the words alone.
7. Quote every meeting at 5–10 minutes. Never "half an hour," never "45 minutes." Low time commitment, high implied value.
8. This week: bring two specific questions to the next training session — verbatim what a buyer said and what stumped you. The team gets sharper when the questions get sharper.

THE RULE OF THUMB Assume the buyer is lying — politely. Bring the data. Use the soft way in. Give them the soft way out. Ask for 5 to 10 minutes — never more. "We need to catch up" closes more meetings than any other line in this playbook.